THE FIRST PUNIC WAR

THE ROMAN REPUBLIC fought the First Punic War against Carthage for control of the island of Sicily. The Romans were dominant on land, but initially the Carthaginians controlled the seas. To challenge this well-established maritime power the Romans had to build a fleet from scratch and teach themselves the skills of naval warfare. They were so successful that the Carthaginians scored only one sizable naval victory in the course of the war—at Drepana—while suffering many defeats, including at Mylae and the huge battle of Cape Ecnomus. The Romans used sea power to carry the war into Carthaginian territory in North Africa, although they suffered catastrophic losses when fleets were sunk by storms in 255, 253, and 249. After a final defeat at the Aegates Islands in 241 the Carthaginians could no longer supply their troops on Sicily by sea and were forced to make peace on Roman terms.



THE FIRST PUNIC WAR 264–241 BCE

In the mid-3rd century BCE territory under Roman control was limited to the Italian mainland. By the terms of the treaty at the end of the war with Carthage, they gained not only Sicily—the original cause of the conflict and scene of most of the fighting—but the islands of Sardinia and Corsica as well.

KEY

- Area controlled by Carthage 264 BCE
- Area controlled by Rome 264 BCE
- Roman gains at end of war
- Carthaginian victory
- Roman victory
- Roman fleet lost in storm

FIRST PUNIC WAR

MYLAE



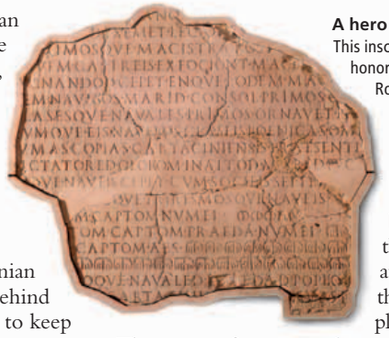
Date 260 BCE
Forces Romans: c.130 ships; Carthaginians: 130 ships
Losses Romans: unknown; Carthaginians: c.45 ships

Location Off northern Sicily

The Romans built a fleet of 100 quinqueremes and 20 triremes in 60 days and somehow found the men to crew them. This inexperienced navy went to sea in 260 and soon lost 17 ships in a skirmish at the Lipari Islands. This inauspicious start led to a swift change at the top, the consul Gaius Duilius taking control of the navy. The Romans realized that their green sailors were no match for the seasoned Carthaginians in a battle of maneuver. On the other hand, no one was better at close-quarters fighting than a Roman soldier. Seeking to exploit their strength, they came up with the corvus as a way of boarding enemy ships and sailed to meet the Carthaginians at Mylae.

Carthaginian commander Hannibal Gisco was puzzled by the Roman ships with the strange-looking devices at their prows. Nonetheless, he led the way as the Carthaginian ships surged forward in loose formation to engage the enemy. The Romans kept their prows turned toward the Carthaginians and at the right moment brought their corvuses crashing downward. Thirty of the Carthaginians' leading ships were pinned, including Hannibal's. Roman soldiers then began to pour across the boarding bridges, slaughtering efficiently with sword and spear. Hannibal had to make his escape in a small rowing boat.

The Carthaginian ships following behind realized they had to keep away from the Roman prows. They maneuvered around the Roman fleet and attacked with their rams from the rear, but still the balance of losses went against them. When the surviving Carthaginian ships broke off the battle, the Romans did not attempt a pursuit. After the battle, the speakers' platform in the Roman forum was decorated with prows cut from enemy ships to celebrate Rome's first naval triumph. Hannibal was crucified by his own captains.

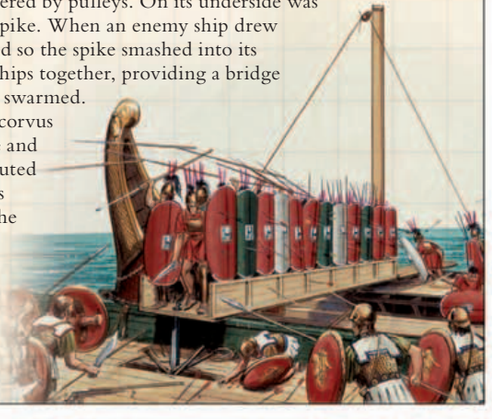


A hero remembered
This inscription in the Roman forum honored Duilius, commander at Rome's victory at Mylae.

WEAPONS AND TECHNOLOGY

CORVUS

The corvus ("raven" in Latin) was an ingenious boarding device adopted by the Romans before the battle of Mylae. Attached by a cable to a pole at the prow of a ship, it was raised and lowered by pulleys. On its underside was a sharp beak-shaped metal spike. When an enemy ship drew near, the corvus was lowered so the spike smashed into its deck. This locked the two ships together, providing a bridge over which Roman soldiers swarmed. Unfortunately ships with a corvus proved dangerously unstable and the device probably contributed to heavy losses in storms. Its use was abandoned before the end of the First Punic War.



Corvus in action
The "beak" of the corvus sticks into the enemy ship's deck as the legionaries march across.

FIRST PUNIC WAR

AEGATES ISLANDS



Date 10 March 241 BCE
Forces Romans: c.200 ships; Carthaginians: c.250 ships
Losses Romans: c.30 ships; Carthaginians: c.120 ships

Location Off coast of western Sicily

In 241 the Carthaginians sent a large fleet to carry grain from North Africa to feed their hard-pressed army in Sicily. The fleet sailed to the Aegates Islands and awaited a favorable wind that would carry it to the Sicilian mainland. But the Romans were well informed of their movements and had a fleet under Caius Catullus ready to intercept. On 10 March a strong breeze blew from the west and Carthaginian commander Hanno ordered the dash for Sicily. The Romans had to row against a heavy swell to get into position, but their now experienced crews coped magnificently and formed a line blocking their enemy's path. The Carthaginians had no choice but to take down their masts, take up their oars, and prepare to fight. They rowed boldly into battle, their crews shouting encouragement to one another from ship to ship, but they were severely overburdened with the supplies they were carrying and short on marines.

The Romans had the better of the contest both in ramming and boarding, sinking 50 enemy ships and capturing another 70. Carthage could no longer deny Rome command of the sea.